

The 2025 *One Big Beautiful Bill Act (OBBBA)* makes numerous amendments to the *Higher Education Act of 1965*, as amended (*HEA*), some of which became effective upon enactment of *OBBBA* while others will become effective on July 1, 2026, and beyond. To ensure that the U.S. Department of Education (ED) can implement those provisions that are effective now or will become effective on July 1, 2026, ED is drafting presentations and documents in advance of publication of a final rule on these topics. These presentations and documents are intended to ensure that vendors, servicers, partners and stakeholders have the requisite time to prepare for the implementation of the *OBBBA*. However, the information is subject to change depending upon ED's rulemaking process. ED has not prejudged the outcome of that negotiated rulemaking process. This information provides a structure for vendors, servicers, partners and stakeholders to begin building these systems, but it does not impair, prevent, or control policy decisions that may be made by ED. The information is preliminary, and ED, including its vendors and servicers, will not launch any new systems or make final system changes that are public facing until ED publishes a final rule on these topics. ED will provide additional information if any changes are made during the rulemaking process.

Volume 1

Getting Started

COMMON ORIGINATION AND DISBURSEMENT

2026 – 2027 Technical Reference

Federal Student Aid
AN OFFICE OF THE U.S. DEPARTMENT OF EDUCATION

Table of Contents

Section 1: Document Standards	2
How to Use This Technical Reference	3
Document Structure	3
Document Conventions	3
Notes & Updates	3
Code Samples	4
Calculations	4
Viewing & Printing the Document	4
Printing Double-Sided	5
FSA Partner and School Relations	5
Section 2: Overview of Changes from 2025-26 to 2026-27	6
Common Origination and Disbursement (COD) Changes	7
Additions to COD for 2026-27	8
Modifications to COD for 2026-27	8
Edits Modified for 2026-27	8
Reporting Changes 2026-27	9
Section 3: COD Overview	12
Common Origination and Disbursement	13
COD Customer Service	14
Common Record Overview	16
Common Record Processing	21

Section 1:

Document Standards

The Common Origination and Disbursement System (COD) Technical Reference includes information for schools using the COD System. School Participants use the XML Common Record to submit Pell Grant, Teacher Education Assistance for higher Education (TEACH) Grant, and/or Direct Loan data to COD. School participants use the XML Campus-Based (CB) Common Record XML to submit Federal Work-Study (FWS) and Federal Supplemental Educational Opportunity Grant (FSEOG) Awards to COD.

The 2026–27 COD Technical Reference contains message classes, edits, record layouts, implementation guides, and supporting information for COD Users.

How to Use This Technical Reference

The 2026–2027 COD Technical Reference is an operational guide that informs schools, vendors, and third-party servicers how to transmit Campus Based, Pell Grant, TEACH Grant, and Direct Loan Origination and Disbursement data to the COD System.

This Technical Reference provides the record layout and data elements that are required for the COD System to successfully process submitted records as well as the record layout and data elements for responses that are returned to participants by the COD System.

The information provided in this Technical Reference is not intended to reflect all Federal regulations that govern the Campus Based, Pell Grant, TEACH Grant, and Direct Loan programs and with which all participants must comply. As such, schools, vendors, and third-party servicers must refer to these regulations and documents such as the Federal Student Aid Handbook, Electronic Announcements, and Dear Colleague Letters for guidance on regulatory compliance.

Document Structure

The 2026–2027 COD Technical Reference is an operational guide that informs schools, vendors, and third-party servicers how to transmit Campus Based, Pell Grant, TEACH Grant, and Direct Loan Origination and Disbursement data to the COD System.

Document Conventions

The following design conventions have been applied to help distinguish between the information presented within this document.

Notes & Updates

Notes and updates are now placed in the margins, as well as important changes to system functionality.

Code Samples

All code samples, field names, and field values are now distinguished from regular text by their font face, Courier New. Extended snippets of code are presented in the following manner:

```
<DLLoanInformation AwardKey="1">  
  
<OriginationFeePercent>1.068</OriginationFeePercent>  
  
<InterestRebatePercent>0</InterestRebatePercent>  
  
<DisclosureStatementPrintCode>Y</DisclosureStatementPrintCode>  
  
<StudentLevelCode>1</StudentLevelCode>  
  
<FinancialAwardBeginDate>2026-09-01</FinancialAwardBeginDate>  
  
<FinancialAwardEndDate>2027-05-15</FinancialAwardEndDate>  
<AcademicYearBeginDate>2026-09-01</AcademicYearBeginDate>  
  
<AcademicYearEndDate>2027-05-15</AcademicYearEndDate>  
  
</DLLoanInformation>
```

Calculations

Calculations have been highlighted and are presented in the following manner:

Eligibility Used Calculation:

$$\text{EU \%} = 100\% \times (\text{Sum of Actual Disbursements of Award} - \text{DMCS Repayments of Award}) \div \text{Scheduled Award Amount}$$

Viewing & Printing the Document

Updates to this document can be found posted on the following website:

- Knowledge Center: [2026-2027 COD Technical Reference – Knowledge Center](#)

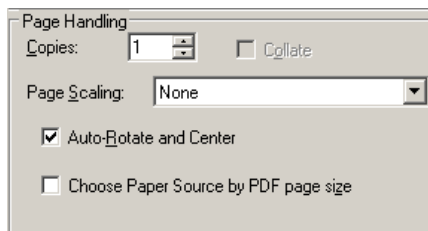


Figure 1: A visual of "Auto-Rotate and Center" selection when printing this document.

Several documents in this Technical Reference will contain sections that are oriented differently, utilizing both landscape and portrait orientations to maximize usability. Some printers may not be automatically configured to print both orientations.

The user may have to configure the printer to auto-rotate the pages. This option can be set immediately before sending the document to the printer by selecting the “Auto-Rotate and Center” option:

Printing Double-Sided

This document is best printed in black and white on a printer that is capable of printing double-sided. Double-sided printing will ensure the mirror-margins appear correctly.

Alternatively, if your printer is unable to print double-sided, you can make sure your document is printed properly by following these suggested steps:

1. Print all even pages of the document
2. Load the even pages into the printer.
3. Print all odd pages of the document.

Please note that printing odd pages first, then even pages, may result in the entire document being collated backwards.

Helpful Tip:

It is helpful to determine the paper orientation required to print on both sides properly so that the odd pages are not on the same side as the even pages or upside-down.

FSA Partner and School Relations

If you have any questions regarding the information contained in this document, please contact the FSA Partner and School Relations Center at the following phone number:

FSA Partner and School Relations Center: 1-800-848-0978

Staff is available Monday through Friday, 10 a.m. – 6 p.m. Eastern Time

The FSA Partner and School Relations Center can also be contacted via live chat at

<https://cod.ed.gov/cod/LoginShortcutPage>, upon login or by Email at COD Customer Service at CODSupport@ed.gov.

Section 2:

Overview of Changes from 2025–26 to 2026–27

This section provides an overview of the changes made for 2026-27 for Common Origination and Disbursement (COD).

Common Origination and Disbursement (COD) Changes

Changes from 2025-26 to 2026-27

The change descriptions are organized by the following two categories: Additions and Modifications. The first column provides a description of each change. The remaining columns indicate which programs the change will affect.

Additions to Common Origination and Disbursement

Description	Pell Grant Program	Direct Loan Program	TEACH Grant Program
Workforce Pell Eligible	X		
Workforce Pell Tuition and Fees	X		
Institutional Limit Applied		X	
Loan Limit Exception		X	
Program Attendance Begin Date		X	
Warning Edit 230	X		

Modifications to Common Origination and Disbursement

Description	Pell Grant Program	Direct Loan Program	TEACH Grant Program
Student Level Code		X	X
Enrollment Intensity	X	X	
Rejecting Edit 039		X	
Rejecting Edit 150		X	
Rejecting Edit 208		X	X
Warning Edit 221	X		
Warning Edit 229	X		
Rejecting Edit 994		X	
Rejecting Edit 996	X	X	X

Additions to COD for 2026-27

Workforce Pell Eligible

A new optional <WorkforcePellEligible> tag will be added, for Pell, indicating whether the student is enrolled in a Workforce eligible program and therefore eligible for Workforce Pell. The tag will be added in the Pell Award Response block in Common Record Schema version 5.0d for Award Year 2026-27 and forward.

Workforce Pell Tuition and Fees

A new optional <WorkforcePellTuitionAndFees> tag will be added, for Pell, tracking tuition and fees for an eligible workforce program at the institution. The tag will be added in the CIP Complex Element for Pell disbursements in Common Record Schema version 5.0d for Award Year 2026-27 and forward.

Enrollment Intensity

The existing <EnrollmentIntensity> tag will be accepted, for Direct Loan, indicating the student's enrollment level for the payment period. The tag will be accepted in the Direct Loan Disbursement block with Common Record Schema version 5.0d. The Enrollment Intensity field will be a required field for new Direct Loan disbursements for the 2026-27 Award Year and forward.

Institutional Limit Applied

A new optional <InstitutionalLimitApplied> tag will be added, for Direct Loan, indicating whether the institution is enforcing an institutional loan limit for the student. The tag will be added in the Direct Loan Disbursement block in Common Record Schema version 5.0d for Award Year 2026-27 and forward.

Loan Limit Exception

A new <LoanLimitException> tag will be added, for Direct Loan, indicating if the student is eligible to be exempted from the new loan limits effective on or after July 1, 2026 for up to 3 years. The tag will be added in the Student Response block in the Common Record Schema version 5.0d for Award Year 2026-27 and forward.

Program Attendance Begin Date

A new optional <ProgramAttendanceBeginDate> tag will be accepted, for Direct Loan, indicating the date when the program's credits were transferred for the student. The tag will be accepted in the Direct Loan Disbursement block in Common Record Schema version 5.0d for Award Year 2026-27 and forward for undergraduate students. The <ProgramAttendanceBeginDate> will not be accepted for graduate students.

Edits Added for 2026-27

Warning Edit 230

The COD System will add a new Warning Edit 230 triggered, for Pell, when a student is Workforce Pell Eligible and the disbursement does not contain the Workforce Pell Tuition and Fees amount. This edit condition will apply to Award Year 2026-27 and forward.

Modifications to COD for 2026-27

COD Schema Update

Common Record schema version will be updated from 5.0c to 5.0d to account for new fields.

Student Level Code

The COD System will update the Student Level Code to add new student level codes 8 through 13 and remove Student Level Code 6 and 7 for graduate and professional students for the Award Year 2026-27 and forward.

For Award Year 2026-2027 and forward:

- 0 = 1st year, undergraduate/never attended college
 - 1 = 1st year, undergraduate/attended college before
 - 2 = 2nd year, undergraduate/sophomore
 - 3 = 3rd year, undergraduate/junior
 - 4 = 4th year, undergraduate/senior
 - 5 = 5th year/other undergraduate
 - 8 = Graduate Never Professional
 - 9 = Graduate was Professional
 - 10 = Professional Never Graduate
 - 11 = Professional was Graduate
 - 12 = Graduate Concurrent Enrollment
 - 13 = Professional Concurrent Enrollment
- For Award Year 2025-2026 and prior, the COD System will continue to accept the following Student Level Codes:
 - 0 = 1st year, undergraduate/never attended college
 - 1 = 1st year, undergraduate/attended college before
 - 2 = 2nd year, undergraduate/sophomore
 - 3 = 3rd year, undergraduate/junior
 - 4 = 4th year, undergraduate/senior
 - 5 = 5th year/other undergraduate
 - 6 = 1st year, graduate/professional
 - 7 = Continuing graduate/professional or beyond

Edits Modified for 2026-27

Rejecting Edit 150

Edit 150 will be modified to reject Direct Loan Graduate PLUS awards with an Award Begin Date and Earliest Disbursement Date on or after July 1, 2026 and the student is not grandfathered into the loan limit exception.

Rejecting Edit 208

Edit 208 will be modified to include the new Student Level Codes for graduate and professional students. The COD System will continue to trigger Edit 208 at the award and disbursement level for Direct Loan and TEACH when the combination of Student Level Code and Program Credential Level is invalid.

Warning Edit 221

Edit 221 will be modified to include the new Student Level Codes for graduate and professional students. The COD System will continue to trigger Edit 221 at the student level when a student has received a Pell LEU Closed School Restoration Adjustment.

Warning Edit 229

Edit 229 will be modified to include the new Student Level Codes for graduate and professional students. The COD System will continue to trigger Edit 229 at the student level when a student has received a Pell LEU Restoration for Discharge Adjustment.

Reporting Changes for 2026-27

COD will update the Pell Grant Year-to-Date (YTD) Record, Pell Grant Reconciliation Report, TEACH Rebuild File, Direct Loan Rebuild File, Direct Loan Duplicate Student Borrower Report, Direct Loan Actual Disbursement List Report, and Direct Loan Pending Disbursement List Report layout by adding fields associated with changes for the Schema 5.0d. COD will also add a new Direct Loan report, the Loan Limit Exception Report. The reporting changes will apply to the 2026-2027 Award Year and forward.

Pell School Reporting

Pell Grant Year-To-Date (YTD) Record

The Pell Grant YTD Origination and Disbursement Records will be updated for the 2026-27 Award Year.

Pell Grant Year-To-Date (YTD) Origination Record

The following field will be added to the Pell Grant YTD Origination Record for the 2026-2027 Award Year and forward:

- Workforce Pell Eligible

Pell Grant Year-To-Date (YTD) Disbursement Record

The following fields will be added to the Pell Grant YTD Disbursement Record for the 2026-2027 Award Year and forward:

- Workforce Pell Tuition and Fees 1
- Workforce Pell Tuition and Fees 2
- Workforce Pell Tuition and Fees 3

Pell Grant Reconciliation Report

The following field will be added to the Pell Grant Reconciliation Report for the 2026-2027 Award Year and forward:

- Workforce Pell Eligible

TEACH School Reporting

TEACH Rebuild File

The TEACH Rebuild Origination Detail Record will be updated for the 2026-27 Award Year and forward to include new valid values for Student Level Code. The TEACH Rebuild Disbursement Detail Record will not be updated for the 2026-2027 Award Year.

Direct Loan School Reporting

Direct Loan School Account Statement (SAS)

The Direct Loan School Account Statement (SAS) will be updated for the 2026-2027 Award Year. The Record Count Sequence # field length will be updated to 7 in the SAS Disbursement Detail Record. The Record Count Sequence # field Start Position will be updated to 444 and the Record Sequence # field End Position will remain as 450. The Total Record Length of the SAS Disbursement Detail Record will not be updated. The Record Count Sequence # field length will not be updated for the 2025-2026 Award Year and prior. If the Record Count Sequence # exceeds a length of 6 for the 2025-2026 Award Year and prior, COD will truncate the Record Count Sequence # field to a length of 6. There will be no changes to the SAS Origination Detail Record.

Direct Loan Rebuild

The Direct Loan Rebuild Origination Detail Record will be updated for the 2026-27 Award Year. The Direct Loan

Rebuild Disbursement Detail Record will be updated for the 2026-27 Award Year.

Direct Loan Rebuild Origination Detail Record

The Direct Loan Rebuild Origination Detail Record will be updated for the 2026-27 award year. The Direct Loan Rebuild Origination Detail Record will maintain a Total Record Length of 1200 characters.

- Student Level Code will be updated to include new valid values for the 2026-2027 Award Year and forward.
- The following field will be added for the 2026-2027 Award Year and forward:
 - Loan Limit Exception

Direct Loan Rebuild Disbursement Detail Record

The Direct Loan Rebuild Disbursement Detail Record will be updated for the 2026-27 Award Year. The Direct Loan Rebuild Disbursement Detail Record will maintain a Total Record Length of 1200 characters.

- The following field(s) will be added for the 2026-27 Award Year:
 - Enrollment Intensity
 - Institutional Limit Applied
 - Program Attendance Begin Date

Direct Loan Duplicate Student Borrower Report

The Direct Loan Duplicate Student Borrower Report will be updated for the 2026-27 Award Year to include Parent PLUS Loans.

Direct Loan Actual Disbursement List Report

The Direct Loan Actual Disbursement List Report will be updated for the 2026-27 Award Year.

- The following field(s) will be added for the 2026-27 Award Year:
 - Institutional Limit Applied
 - Enrollment Intensity
 - Program Attendance Begin Date

Direct Loan Pending Disbursement List Report

The Direct Loan Pending Disbursement List Report will be updated for the 2026-27 Award Year.

- The following field(s) will be added for the 2026-27 Award Year:
 - Institutional Limit Applied
 - Enrollment Intensity
 - Program Attendance Begin Date

Loan Limit Exception Report

A new Loan Limit Exception Report will be created for the 2026-2027 Award Year and forward for the Direct Loan program. The newly created Loan Limit Exception Report will be available via the COD Reporting Website. This report will be in Comma Delimited format and include the following fields:

- Institutional OPE ID
- Institution Name
- Student's Last Name
- Student's Name Suffix
- Student's First Name

- Student Middle Name
- Student's Current SSN
- Student's Date of Birth
- Loan Limit Exception Flag
- Graduate/Professional or Parent PLUS Indicator

Section 3:

COD Overview

Common Origination and Disbursement

The Common Origination and Disbursement (COD) System was implemented in April 2002 by the Office of Federal Student Aid (FSA) to re-engineer the process of delivering and reporting Federal Pell Grants and Direct Loans from two processes into one Common Origination and Disbursement Process. This section will provide an overview of the COD System, contact information for COD Customer Service, and high-level information regarding the common record files and how they are processed through COD.

The *Higher Education Reconciliation Act of 2005* (HERA) also introduced the PLUS loan for graduate and professional student borrowers (Grad PLUS). The COD System processes Grad PLUS for the 2005-06 award year and forward. The *One Big Beautiful Bill (OBBB) Act* eliminates PLUS loans for graduate and professional student borrowers, effective July 1, 2026, unless the student is currently enrolled, remains in the same program and has received a loan prior to July 1, 2026.

On September 27, 2007, Congress enacted the College Cost Reduction and Access Act (CCRAA), which established the Teacher Education Assistance for College and Higher Education (TEACH) Grant Program. On July 1, 2008, the COD System began processing TEACH Grant awards for the 2008-09 Award Year and forward.

The stand-alone Iraq and Afghanistan Service Grant (IASG) was applicable for Award Year 2010-11 through 2023-24. This allowed Pell-ineligible students, identified by the Department of Defense as a dependent of a veteran who died as a result of service in Iraq or Afghanistan, to be awarded Iraq and Afghanistan Service Grant funds.

COD provides a common process and an integrated system that enables efficient delivery of Title IV Funds. COD allows for:

Common Processing:

- One process and record for submitting origination and disbursement data
- Edits that are common across the Pell Grant, TEACH Grant, and Direct Loan programs
- Data tags that are common across the Pell Grant, TEACH Grant, and Direct Loan programs, and are (approaching) a cross-industry standard for data definitions
- Elimination of duplicate data reporting for Pell Grants, TEACH Grant, and Direct Loans
- Streamlined edits to reduce turnaround time for exception processing

Campus-Based (CB) Common Processing:

- One process and record for submitting Campus-Based data.
- Edits that are common across the FWS Award and FSEOG programs
- Data tags that are common across the FWS Award and FSEOG programs, and are (approaching) a cross-industry standard for data definitions
- Elimination of duplicate data reporting for FWS Awards and FSEOG

Expanded online capability to make corrections/changes, to process “emergency” requests, and to check transmission status

In general, the COD Process is a simplified process for requesting, reporting, and reconciling Title IV funds.

COD Website Cookies

The COD website uses a “cookie” to help visitors use the website interactively. A cookie is a small file that a website transfers to the user’s computer hard disk, usually for the purpose of tracking the user’s activity while he or she is connected to that site.

The cookie on this site does not collect any information about the user, only about the user’s browser session. The cookie makes it easier for users to use the dynamic features on these web pages, without having to provide the same information repeatedly as the user moves from one page to another, essentially confirming that a valid log-in was performed each time the user moves to another page. If a user has his or her computer set to block all cookies, the cookie is not created at log-in. As a result, the COD website cannot validate when the user moves from one web page to another. If the COD website cannot validate the user, the user’s session is terminated, and the user is forced to log in again. **To avoid this situation, all users must set their Internet browser Privacy settings for cookies to “high” or less.**

COD Users

A COD User utilizes the Common Record in XML format to submit Pell Grant, TEACH Grant, and/or Direct Loan origination and disbursement data to the COD System.

COD Participants may submit data to the COD System in two ways:

- Batch processing of Common Record documents over the Student Aid Internet Gateway (SAIG).
- Manual entry of Common Record data using the COD website.

Users should refer to 2026-27 COD Technical Reference, Volume 2 - Common Record Technical Reference for record layouts and processes.

A COD User also utilizes the Campus-Based (CB) Common Record in XML format to submit FWS and FSEOG Awards to the COD System.

COD Participants in the Campus-Based FWS and FSEOG programs may submit data to the COD System in two ways:

- Batch processing of CB Common Record documents over the Student Aid Internet Gateway (SAIG).
- Manual entry of CB Common Record data using the COD website.

Users should refer to the COD Technical Reference, Volume 4 – Campus-Based Processing Technical Reference for record layouts and processes.

COD website & Privacy

For more information about the COD website privacy, please go to: <https://cod.ed.gov/cod/Privacy>

COD Customer Service

The FSA Partner and School Relations Center integrates customer service for the Campus Based, Direct Loan, TEACH Grant, and Pell Grant Programs.

All schools should use the following number or email address listed below for assistance: FSA Partner and School Relations Center:

- 1-800-848-0978
- CODSupport@ed.gov

The FSA Partner and School Relations Center can also be contacted via live chat on [COD website](#), upon login.

The COD System does not print or mail paper MPNs to borrowers or schools. Borrowers may still complete a paper MPN by downloading the form from StudentAid.gov and mailing the completed form to Federal Student Aid. Mail completed Promissory Notes to:

US Department of Education
P.O. Box 1130
Fairfax, VA 22038

Overnight Mail:

U.S. Department of Education
4050 Legato Rd #1100
Fairfax, VA 22033

Schools choosing to create Master Promissory Note (MPN) forms instead of using Department provided forms must submit them for testing and review only to:

Submitting MPNs for Test and Review

All documents and shipping packages should be clearly marked "For Testing Only".

US Department of Education
P.O. Box 1130
Fairfax, VA 22038

Overnight Mail:

U.S. Department of Education
4050 Legato Rd #1100
Fairfax, VA 22033

Common Record Overview

The Common Origination and Disbursement process utilizes one single record across programs for both origination and disbursement. Participants use a Common Record, one that uses common data elements, definitions, edits, and structure for Pell Grants, TEACH Grants, and Direct Loans. Although the record has the same layout for all programs, not all data elements are required for each transmission. This record layout relies on a technology called the eXtensible Markup Language, or XML.

The Common Record was developed in partnership with members of the National Council of Higher Education Loan Programs (NCHELP) and the Postsecondary Electronic Standards Council (PESC). This collaborative effort enables the Common Record to bring consistency and standardization to the transmission of student financial aid data.

What Is XML?

XML stands for eXtensible Markup Language. XML is a recommendation by the World Wide Web Consortium (W3C) for how to represent structured information in a text-based format. XML is a markup language whose roots originate in HTML and SGML. Like HTML, XML consists of elements that are defined by tags. A start tag containing a name precedes element data; an end tag follows it. While HTML tags have a specific meaning and generally describe how the text between them should look, XML uses tags only to delimit pieces of data and leaves the interpretation of the data completely to the application. The tags identify data elements and provide metadata, or meaning, for the information that appears between the tags.

The textual and self-describing nature of XML makes its platform independent and very flexible in terms of content. It is an open standard for storing, publishing, and exchanging any kind of information between any number of disparate systems. As long as two parties agree on and adhere to a common data structure, they can transfer information to each other without any knowledge of the other party's operating system, database type or programming language. XML can be used in conjunction with HTML to store data within standard web pages. It can also be used to store data in files and to pull information from disparate, incompatible databases.

One of the objectives behind the design of the COD Process and System was to provide FSA and our partnering student aid schools greater flexibility in record processing, i.e., opportunities for multiple data crosswalks. The COD Process could serve as a technological foundation for future FSA integration initiatives. Given these objectives, XML was the logical choice for the Common Record's format and structure. XML offers the flexibility to design records, known as XML documents, particular to an audience or community. It allows increased access to and reuse of information. It supports validation edits by checking structural validity and flagging errors. It also enables systems to share information and users to see different views of available data.

XML 101

XML technology allows a common data packet structure to be used between two disparate systems. It is a markup language that defines data structure. An XML document is the vehicle through which data is transmitted. It can be thought of as a batch.

XML documents are comprised of markup and content. Markup defines the content. For example,

`LastName` is the markup describing the content, `Jones`.

```
<LastName>Jones</LastName>
```

`<LastName>` is a start tag. Note the presence of brackets. `LastName` is an element. `Jones` is the data, or XML content. `</LastName>` is an end tag.

Elements can be either complex or simple. A complex element is a grouping of attributes or other elements. The Common Record is a logical grouping of complex elements. In the following example, the Complex Element is bolded.

Complex Element:

`<Name>`

`<FirstName>Heidi</FirstName>`

`<LastName>Smith</LastName>`

`</Name>`

A simple element refers to the value that is contained within tags. In the following example, the two simple elements are bolded.

Simple Element:

`<Name>`

`<FirstName>Heidi</FirstName>`

`<LastName>Smith</LastName>`

`</Name>`

Fixed-Format Files vs. XML Documents

Fixed-format files have been used as vehicles through which data can be exported and imported to business applications. Fixed-format files contain a sequence of fields that is in machine-readable language. An example of a comma-separated, fixed-format file follows:

Sally, Anne, Smith Jr., 299999999, 1980-02-03, IN, DL222222, false, P, 417 Halper Road, Fort Wayne, IN, 46807, Allen, USA, 219799999, sally.a.smith@email.net, 1, 221784902

In the above comma-separated fixed-format file, it is difficult to understand what the data means. There is also no way to validate the document to make sure that the data is represented in a format that can be read by the receiving application.

XML is a language that is not only machine readable, but also human readable. It also has a mechanism to ensure the validity of the document format through the use of XML schemas. As a result, business applications are rapidly moving toward the use of XML to exchange data. The following example demonstrates that XML not only represents data in a human readable text format, but also provides meaning to the data through the use of tags. This is how a student record similar to the one represented in the fixed-format file above would be represented in XML:

`<Student>`

`<Index>`

`<SSN>299999999</SSN>`

`<BirthDate>1980-02-03</BirthDate>`

`<LastName>Smith</LastName>`

`</Index>`

```
<Contacts>

  <PermanentAddress>

    <AddressLine>417 Hapler Road</AddressLine>
    <City>Fort Wayne</City>
    <StateProvinceCode>IN</StateProvinceCode>
    <PostalCode>46807</PostalCode>

  </PermanentAddress>

  <Phone>

    <PhoneNumber>219-799-9999</PhoneNumber>

  </Phone>

  <Email>

    <EmailAddress>sally.a.smith@email.net</EmailAddress>

  </Email>

</Contacts>

<Citizenship>

  <CitizenshipStatusCode>1</CitizenshipStatusCode>

</Citizenship>

<Note>

  <SchoolNoteMessage>New Person</SchoolNoteMessage>

</Note>

</Student>
```

Figure 2: A student record represented in XML format

Common Record Structure

The XML document called the Common Record is composed of different information modules, referred to as complex elements or blocks. Data fields within the blocks emphasize similarities across programs and contain information such as document or batch information, school or entity information, person information, award or origination information, disbursement information, and the response status of the record.

A general rule regarding sequence of data within blocks, and within complex elements: the start and end data tags and their content must be presented on the XML document within the block's tags or the complex element tags to which they belong. The sequence of the data within that block or element is dictated by the sequence of the data tags presented in the XML Common Record Schema. For example, if a complex element has ten simple elements within it, those ten elements must occur in the same sequence as depicted in the XML Common Record Schema.

The Common Record is organized into the following structure:

Quick Reference Block Description

Number	Block Name	Block Description
1	Document Information	The Document Information Block contains information that was previously associated with a batch. It contains a date/time stamp, document validation information, summary-level document information, as well as the source of the document. This block occurs once per XML Document or submission.
2	Entity Information	The Entity Information Block contains information about the reporting and attending school. This block occurs once per reporting entity or school within the XML Document or submission.
3	Person Information	The Person Block contains student or parent information. This block occurs once per person, except for Grad PLUS where there will be two person blocks with identical data. All data within the two Grad PLUS blocks must be identical.
4	Award Information	The Award Information Block contains Direct Loan, Pell Grant, and TEACH Grant award information, similar to origination data submitted in the fixed-length record layouts. This block occurs once per award per person.
5	Disbursement Information	The Disbursement Information Block contains Direct Loan, Pell Grant, and TEACH Grant disbursement information. This block occurs once per disbursement.
6	Response	A Response block is nested within each block. The Response block is returned by COD to the submitting entity upon processing the Common Record. The Response block contains information about processing edits and document status.

Figure 3: How COD is organized regarding quick reference blocks

Below is a pictorial representation of the Common Record layout. It illustrates how the Common Record is comprised of information modules or blocks.

The Common Record Document Structure

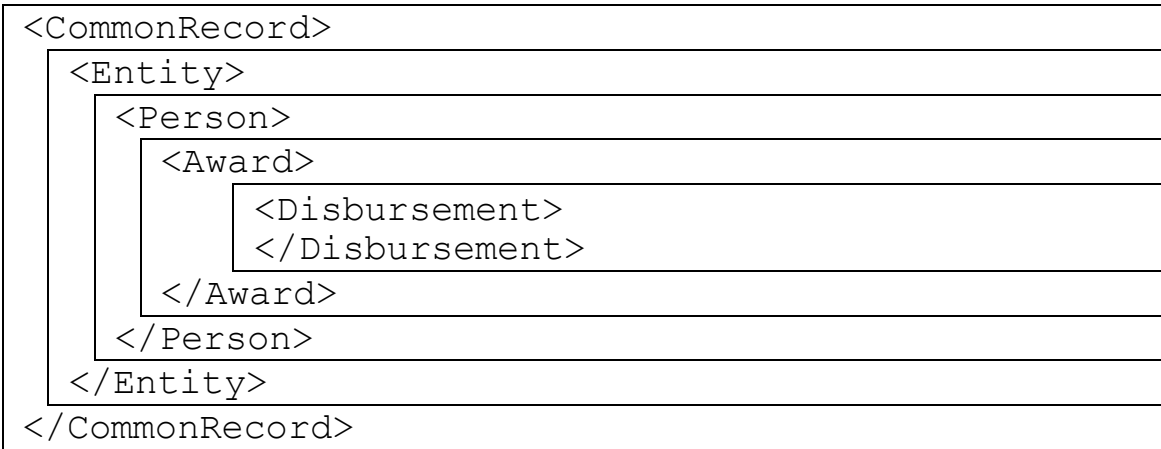


Figure 4: Example of a Common Record Document Structure

These information modules or blocks may be reused many times in the same record to transmit data for multiple awards and multiple disbursements for one or multiple students by one or multiple Attended Schools.

XML Schema

An XML Schema specifies the rules surrounding the logical structure of an XML document. It is a language that describes the allowed content of documents. It defines the elements present in the document and the order in which they appear, as well as any attributes that may be associated with an element.

To support the open standards proven effective in the development of the Common Record, FSA is making the XML Schema for the Common Record available electronically to all interested parties. Whether a school, a software provider, or a third-party servicer is using it for product development to support COD or any student financial resource trading partner is interested in incorporating the Common Record into their products and services, the schema is available on the web at: <https://fsapartners.ed.gov/knowledge-center/library/resource-type/COD%20XML%20Schema>

Schema Version

All records containing Award Year 2026-27 (and forward) data should be submitted in the 5.0d schema.

Schools may continue to send records for prior Award Years in earlier schema versions (4.0a, 4.0b, 4.0c, 4.0d, 4.0e, 5.0a, 5.0b, and 5.0c only).

XML Resources

Extensible Markup Language (XML) is a growing standard for e-commerce, data transmissions and structured documents using the Internet. Many industry groups are developing schemas and data dictionaries for this purpose. As a result, there is extensive information available about XML and the initiatives specific to the higher education community. Many institutions are already using XML for their own Internet initiatives, including self-service applications for students, faculty, and staff; data exchanges both within and outside the school, and even data coordination or backup with data warehouse projects.

Available resources about XML include courses at many institutions and local or Internet bookstores. The Web is also a resource, including the sites mentioned below. The first three are international standards bodies, and the last is specifically for the schema and data dictionary for higher education.

- <https://www.w3.org/>
- <http://www.ebXML.org>
- <http://www.oasis-open.org/>
- <https://www.pesc.org/>
- Sun's XML & Java Technologies: <https://www.oracle.com/java/technologies/>
- O'Reilly XML.com: <https://www.xml.com/>

Literature is constantly being updated as new technologies develop and mature. Therefore, it is recommended that time be spent exploring these resources.

Common Record Processing

This section addresses at a high level the processing of the Common Record from the institution perspective.

The COD Process is comprised of the following steps:



Figure 5: The COD Process

Please note that this overview of the COD Process will not cover the entire cycle for a school. There are items that take place prior to the submission of records (i.e. packaging) that are not explained in this document.

Common Record Submission

The COD Process begins when a school submits a Common Record. The Common Record is submitted by schools in one of two ways:

- Batch Submission via Student Aid Internet Gateway (SAIG)
- Manual Online Submission via the COD website

Batch Submission

All Common Records sent in batch mode are submitted to COD's SAIG mailbox. The Enterprise Application Integration Bus (EAI Bus) performs periodic sweeps of COD's SAIG mailbox and transmits the Common Record data to the COD System.

Online Submission

A COD User can manually enter data online via the COD website. The COD website creates a Common Record document for data entered online and sends it directly to the COD System.

For Common Record Processing of Subsidized/Unsubsidized Direct Loans, the Student Identifier submitted by a school to establish the student on COD, is matched to data from the FAFSA® Processing System (FPS). For Campus-Based (CB) Awards FWS and FSEOG, the Student Identifier submitted by a school to establish the student on COD is matched to data from the FAFSA® Processing System (FPS).

For Pell Grant and TEACH Grant, the current SSN, current Date of Birth, and first two characters of the current Last Name are matched with FPS data.

Upon receiving a record, the COD System classifies the record to determine how it is to be processed. The types of records are:

- New Record
- Update/Maintenance Record

New Record

A New Record establishes a new person, award or disbursement on the COD System. There are three types of new records:

New Person with New Award – If the SSN contained in the student identifier does not match any previously submitted to the COD System, then the record is considered a New Student. Any New Student Record must contain a New Award Record. For Pell Grant, TEACH Grant, and Direct Loan, the current SSN and current Date of Birth are matched with FPS data.

New Award – If the student identifier matches an SSN already established on the COD System, then the system checks to determine if the award is already on file. If not, then the record is considered a New Award.

New Disbursement – If the person and award already exist on the COD System, then the system checks the disbursement number submitted for the award. If it is not already on file, then the system logs the disbursement as a new disbursement. There are two types of disbursement records:

- **Actual Disbursement** – Actual Disbursement Records contain a `<DisbursementReleaseIndicator>` equal to true. The `<DisbursementReleaseIndicator>` is a tag on the Common Record that signals to the COD System that the disbursement information is an actual disbursement. It either makes funds available to a school, or substantiates cash already made available to the school. These records affect the Current Funding Level (CFL) calculation for the school.
- **Award Already on File** – For Direct Loans and TEACH Grants, the Financial Award Type, Financial Award Year, Attended Entity ID, Reporting Entity ID, and Financial Award ID fields are checked to determine if the award is already on file.
- **Anticipated Disbursement** – Anticipated Disbursement Records contain a `<DisbursementReleaseIndicator>` equal to false or omitted. If the `<DisbursementReleaseIndicator>` is omitted, the indicator will default to false. These disbursements are not considered Actual Disbursements; therefore, they do not substantiate drawdowns. These records do not affect the CFL calculation for the school.

Update/Maintenance Record

An Update/Maintenance Record performs a change to information or elements that were previously established on the COD System by a New Record. There are two types of Update/Maintenance Records:

Update/Maintenance Record – An Update/Maintenance Record performs a change to a data element that was previously established by a New Record or is used to change disbursement amounts and dates that occur prior to substantiating drawdowns.

Release Record – A Release Record can be submitted to the COD System with a `<DisbursementReleaseIndicator>` equal to true for a disbursement record previously submitted as an Anticipated Disbursement Record. Data elements can be changed via the COD website or by resubmission of a Common Record. Once the release indicator is set to true, there will no longer be an anticipated disbursement on the system with the same disbursement number as the actual.

Common Record Editing

Once the Common Record is received and has been classified, the COD System performs a series of valid format and content edits to determine if the file is suitable for further processing.

The COD System performs three types of edits:

- **Correction** – For Pell Grant data, if the school selects this option, the system automatically corrects the data and sends a response to the entity that submitted the record indicating that a correction took place, the element corrected, the original value, and the corrected value. The default option in the COD System for all schools is set to 'correct'. If a school wants to have COD reject data instead of correcting it, then it must contact the FSA Partner and School Relations Center to request that FSA make this change.
- **Warning** – The COD System sends a response to the entity that submitted the record indicating a warning, the warning code and the relevant element. The record continues to be processed by the COD System.
- **Reject** – The COD System sends a response to the entity that submitted the record indicating the reject code, the reject reason(s) and the relevant element(s). The record requires action from the school to continue processing.

Where possible, COD uses information from FPS as a basis for these edits. COD receives the information from FPS on a daily basis. This file is used to:

Confirm a valid Institutional Student Information Record (ISIR) is on file (if applicable) and, Pell student-level information required for Common Record processing.

Note:

The Common Record can be resubmitted in its entirety or sent with just the key identifiers, minimum data elements required for processing, and those data elements that have changed.

The COD System performs edits on the Document, Entity, Person, Award and Disbursement levels of the Common Record data. Data that passes edits is accepted and continues to be processed while data that does not pass edits is rejected. The COD System stores rejected data and associated reject reasons.

Rejected data is held for corrective action to be taken by the school. Data can be corrected via Common Record re-submission or via the COD website. The COD System then returns a response record notifying the school of the edit results.

Response Documents

For all Common Records received and processed by the COD System, the COD System returns a Response document indicating the status of the Common Record processing, including any rejected data elements and the reason for the rejection. If the Common Record was accepted, then the Response document indicates that the record was accepted.

The COD System sends one Response document for each Common Record document submitted. For Common Records that are transmitted via the SAIG, the COD System sends Response documents to the school's SAIG mailbox. For Common Record data entered into the COD website, schools have an option to receive a Response document via their SAIG mailbox in addition to seeing the response via the COD website.

For Responses received via the SAIG mailbox, schools also have the option to receive a Full or a Standard Response to Common Records processed by the COD System. A Full Response contains all the original tags sent by the school and the rejected data elements and reason codes. A Standard Response contains only the minimum tags, the rejected data elements and reason codes.

Record Layouts and Processes

For further information regarding record layouts and processes, schools/software vendors should refer to Volume 2 – Common Record Technical Reference.

For examples of COD Response Documents, please refer to Volume 7, Section 1 – COD System Generated XML Response Files and Section 2 – COD Common Record Input and Response Examples.

If you use a combination of EDEExpress and another system, please refer to Volume 3 – Pell Grant & Direct Loan Combination System Supplement for record layouts, processes, and edits pertinent to working in a combination system.